

Wake up

The Insignia alarm clock comes with a radio and a digital photo frame all packed into one

Nokia touch

Nokia 5230 Touchscreen phone available in India at an official price of around Rs. 9,000



The LaBiche FSC-1 is the perfect hybrid flying

titled 'Switchblade' flying bike up for display in a few months.

Parajet Skycar

The Parajet Skycar actually flew and drove its way from London to Timbuktu in January 2009 without a hitch and has been declared the world's first legal flying car. It has a top speed of 180 kmph and a maximum range of 400 kilometres. The car is basically constructed from a dune buggy combined with a paramotor (one of those paragliding contraptions which have a set of motorised propellers at the pilot's back) for greater thrust and propulsion and a parafoil (the flat sail of a paraglider) to increase the lift.

Hoverpod

Entecho, an Australian company has combined a new rotor technology with unique lifting surfaces to create a flying machine that looks like a typical flying saucer. A centrifugal fan causes the air under the car to move radially from the centre towards the outside, generating lift as the 'skirt' – the airtight flexible membrane beneath the level of the rotor – blows up, directing the flow of the air downwards.

Automotive amphibians

Want to avoid the traffic jam on the bridge? No sweat. Just press a button and glide across the water at the speed of a motor boat. If you think this sounds like a James Bond movie, here is a list of amazing amphibious vehicles to make you think again.

Aquada

Using High Speed Amphibian technology (HAS), Gibbs Technologies led by Alan Gibbs has launched the Aquada in the USA. The HAS is a technology that has been developed over a period of seven years and can now even be applied to vehicles weighing up to

10 tonnes. The Aquada can travel at a maximum speed of 160 kmph on land and of about 49 kmph on water. Unlike the Volkswagen Schwimmwagen launched in 1942, it does not create bow waves to hinder progress over water, but proceeds smoothly like a typical motor boat. The Aquada is a three-seater with only one seat in front. You step into it like you would in a boat but steer it like a car. It uses a 175-horsepower, V6, 2.5-liter, 24-valve engine that enables it to accelerate from 0 to 96 kilometres per hour in less than 60 seconds. Once it enters the water, the wheels can be retracted, like in an airplane, thus significantly reducing the drag. With the press of a button, the wheels retract, the car senses it is in water, activates the jet to propel it in water and changes the headlights into marine lights. It is buoyant and cannot sink. Priced at almost \$3,00,000, it still lies beyond the average person's buying capacity. Gibbs Technologies is also working on the 'Humdinga' – a concept four-wheel drive car that aims to seat five people and hit speeds of 160 kmph on land and 64 kmph on water.

Sir Tristram

Peter Martin of Northern Ireland, in October 2009, used an outboard motor, welding equipment and waterproof sealant on a Renault Laguna he had purchased for 100 pounds sterling and converted it into an amphibious vehicle. This car-boat, named Sir Tristram covered about 20 miles over sea from Ireland to Scotland, in 7 hours. This one, however, is not a prototype and seems to be a one-off. Martin's vehicle is to be auctioned on eBay for the benefit of the Help for Heroes charity that assists wounded British soldiers.



No more cruising on the highway

Python

WaterCar, Inc was founded by Dave March in California. The company hand-makes customised amphibious vehicles in two designs, viz. the Python and the Gator – both of which are said to achieve 60 mph or 95 kmph on water and achieve the same speed in 4.5 seconds on the roads. It offers hundreds of colours to choose from for exteriors as well as interiors, making each car exclusive enough to pay the hefty price tag of 200,000 \$. You can see the car in action at www.thinkdigit.com/d/carvid/

Riding on air

According to Praveen Nahar, Head of the Transportation and Automobile Design at NID (National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad), sustainable design is the inevitable future of the automobile. While the Copenhagen summit may not have seen any significant breakthroughs for environmental conservation, car



Fly like an alien

designers and manufacturers all over the world have been quietly working to ensure that our automobiles cut down on harmful emissions. One of these options is the compressed air car – or the car that runs on air – or hybrid versions of the same.

Air Car

In an extraordinary tie-up with Luxembourg based MDI (Motor Development International), Tata Motors (India) has been working hard for the last two years, to put the finishing touches to a technology that will enable their cars to run on air. With fossil fuels diminishing, fuel prices skyrocketing and global warming threatening us, this couldn't have come at a better time. The only trouble with air-compression engines is the extremes in temperature. When compressed air is released, these engines become extremely cool, making it difficult to operate